

LIFE AFTER ALICE

Episode 1: "Contingency"

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Cold open. First draft, before the screenwriting-skills
rewrite.
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COLD OPEN

FADE IN:

INT. THERAPIST'S WAITING ROOM - MORNING

A small room. One flickering tube light. A plastic fern. A water cooler that gurgles like it's trying to say something.

DANIEL (40s, rumpled, holding a clipboard like it might bite) sits beside ALICE (40s, thin, headscarf, sharp-eyed and very much alive). She peels a satsuma, stacking the peel in a neat pile on her knee.

Daniel stares at an intake form. His pen hovers.

INSERT - THE FORM:

INSERT TEXT: "Reason for seeking support: _____"

He writes nothing.

ALICE
Put "logistics."

DANIEL
I'm not putting "logistics."

ALICE
It's honest.

DANIEL
It's a therapy form, Al. Not a removal van.

She takes the clipboard, writes it in big capitals -- LOGISTICS -- and hands it back with a segment of satsuma. He eats it. He doesn't look at her.

A door opens. RUTH (60s, cardigan, unhurried, has seen everything) leans out.

RUTH
Alice and Daniel?

ALICE
(standing, brightly)
For now.

Daniel closes his eyes.

INT. RUTH'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Two armchairs. A sofa. A box of tissues placed with great intention in the centre of a low table.

Alice takes an armchair. Daniel takes the far end of the sofa -- as far as the furniture allows.

Ruth sits. Lets the silence settle. She's comfortable in it. They are not.

RUTH
So. In your own words -- why are
you here?

Beat. Daniel looks at Alice. Alice looks at Ruth.

ALICE
I'm dying.

RUTH
Yes. I read the referral. I'm very
sorry.

ALICE
Thank you. So that's me sorted.
(nodding at Daniel)
We're here for him.

DANIEL
We're here for us.

ALICE
There won't be an "us." That's the
point.

Silence. A clock ticks. Daniel picks at a loose thread on the sofa arm.

RUTH
Daniel. What do you think the point
is?

DANIEL
(long pause)
She bought a notebook.

FLASH TO:

INT. KITCHEN, THEIR HOUSE - NIGHT (THREE WEEKS EARLIER)

Rain on the window. A single lamp. Alice at the table, writing in a black notebook. On the cover, in silver marker: LIFE AFTER ALICE.

Daniel in the doorway, dressing gown, bare feet.

DANIEL
What's that?

ALICE
(not looking up)
Boiler code. Bins go out Thursday,
recycling the other Thursday. Your
mum's birthday is the ninth, not
the nineteenth --

DANIEL
Stop.

ALICE
-- you always get it wrong --

DANIEL
Alice. Stop.

She does. She looks up. Her eyes are wet. Her voice isn't.

ALICE
Somebody has to.

BACK TO:

INT. RUTH'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

The same notebook now sits on Alice's lap like a hymn book.

RUTH
May I?

Alice hands it over. Ruth turns the pages slowly -- dense handwriting, coloured tabs, a hand-drawn diagram of the fuse box.

RUTH (CONT'D)
This is very thorough.

ALICE
I was a project manager for eleven
years.

DANIEL
(muttering)
And she's managing this one.

ALICE
Say it properly, then.

DANIEL
I just did.

ALICE
No, you said it to the sofa. Say it
to me.

Daniel turns to face her. First time since they sat down.

DANIEL
You're planning my life like it's a
wedding. Seating plans. Colour
schemes. "Daniel will be sad from
March to June, then he'll take up
cycling" --

ALICE
I never wrote cycling.

DANIEL
Page fourteen!

ALICE
That's exercise. That's a
suggestion.

DANIEL
I don't want suggestions. I want
you.

It lands. Nobody moves. Ruth doesn't rescue them.

Alice looks down at her hands.

ALICE
(quietly)
That's not on the menu, love.

FLASH TO:

INT. HOSPITAL CORRIDOR - DAY (EIGHT MONTHS EARLIER)

Harsh strip lights. A humming vending machine. Daniel paces.
Alice sits on a plastic chair, holding a leaflet:
UNDERSTANDING YOUR DIAGNOSIS.

DANIEL
Second opinion. Third. There's a
clinic in --

ALICE
Dan.

DANIEL
-- Germany, I read about it, they
do this thing with --

ALICE
Dan. Sit down.

He doesn't. He can't. He punches the vending machine -- not
hard enough to break it, just hard enough to hurt himself.

A packet of crisps drops anyway.

They both stare at it.

Alice starts to laugh -- a horrible, helpless laugh. After a
second, so does he. He slides down the wall beside her and
puts his head in her lap.

ALICE
(stroking his hair)
Salt and vinegar. At least it's not
prawn cocktail.

BACK TO:

INT. RUTH'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Ruth closes the notebook gently. Holds it a moment before
handing it back.

RUTH
I'd like to try something. Daniel
-- not from the book. Just from
you.

DANIEL
Okay.

RUTH
It's a Tuesday. A year from now.
Seven in the evening. Where are
you?

Daniel opens his mouth. Nothing.

DANIEL

I... it's --

He looks at Alice. She's watching him with enormous tenderness. And something like fear.

DANIEL (CONT'D)

I don't know. I can't see it. Every time I try there's just... the kitchen. And the lamp's on. And you're not there.

Long pause. Alice's jaw tightens. She fights it. Then she doesn't.

ALICE

(barely)

That's why I wrote the book.

DANIEL

I know.

ALICE

Because I can see it. I can see you standing in that kitchen not knowing where the bloody colander is, and it kills me, Dan. More than the -- more than this.

She gestures at herself. At all of it.

Daniel moves. Crosses the gap between sofa and chair and kneels on the carpet in front of her. Arms around her waist, head against her stomach.

The same shape as the hospital corridor.

She holds his head. Closes her eyes.

Ruth quietly slides the tissue box an inch closer. Nobody takes one.

HOLD on the embrace. The clock. Rain starting outside.

A long moment. Then --

DANIEL

(muffled)

Where is the colander?

ALICE

(half laugh, half sob)

Bottom left. Behind the slow cooker you never use.

DANIEL
I use the slow cooker.

ALICE
You've used it once.

He looks up at her and smiles, wrecked. She wipes his face with her sleeve.

Ruth glances at the clock.

RUTH
We're nearly at time. Before next week, I'd like you each to write one thing in that book.
(to Daniel)
Something you want, for after. Not what she wants for you.
(to Alice)
And something you want for now.

Alice opens the notebook to a blank page at the very back. Holds the pen out to Daniel.

He takes it. Stares at the page a long time. Writes.

INSERT - THE NOTEBOOK. His messy scrawl:

INSERT TEXT: "Learn to make her lasagne. Badly."

Alice reads it. Presses her lips together. Nods. Takes the pen back.

INSERT - THE NOTEBOOK. Her neat capitals beneath:

INSERT TEXT: "DANCE IN THE KITCHEN. THIS FRIDAY. LAMP ON."

She closes the book.

ALICE
(to Ruth -- standing, brisk again)
Same time next week?

RUTH
Same time next week.

Alice heads for the door. Daniel follows -- stops. Turns back.

DANIEL
(quietly)
And after? When it's just me?

RUTH
(gently)
Same time. Same chair.

He nods. He goes.

Ruth sits alone in the quiet office. She looks at the empty armchair where Alice sat.

She leaves it empty.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD: LIFE AFTER ALICE

END OF COLD OPEN